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THE RETURN TO DEMOCRACY (2008–2015)

The impact of Cyclone Nargis

The repression after the 1988 revolt did not resolve anything. The opposition survived and slowly the NLD and organisations of Buddhist monks forged a closer alliance. Equally, for most Burmese life became harder. In September 2007 there were widespread protests, known as the Saffron Revolution; these too were harshly put down.

The 2007 wave of unrest was again triggered by economic mismanagement, and monks again made the symbolic gesture of overturning their alms bowls[1] to signal their rejection of the regime. In turn, the army attacked and closed a number of monasteries. The revolt was successfully supressed, but the Saffron Revolution cemented the alliance between the NLD and the monks and this left the regime even more isolated and vulnerable as it lost the legitimacy it had sought from the Buddhist religious establishment. Furthermore, monasteries were increasingly providing education and food relief for those left impoverished,[2] giving the monks a renewed status among the population and increasing their influence relative to that of the military establishment.

However, it was the impact of Cyclone Nargis in 2008 that proved to be pivotal in forcing at least the appearance of serious political change. Cyclones are a typical part of the Burmese climate and often hit the region during the spring monsoon (usually March to May). Nargis was unusually fierce in part due to the geography of Burma. Most such cyclones travel north across the Bay of Bengal towards Bangladesh and lose power when they hit the coastal hills and mountains of Arakan. This time the storm directly stuck the Irrawaddy Delta and, caught up on the coastal